

Beats and measures

Most music has a regular beat or pulse, like a ticking clock, that propels it forward in time. A conductor stands in front of an orchestra to show the beat and keep everyone together.

SEE ALSO

◀ 14–15 High and low

◀ 16–17 The piano keyboard

◀ 18–19 Notes on the staff

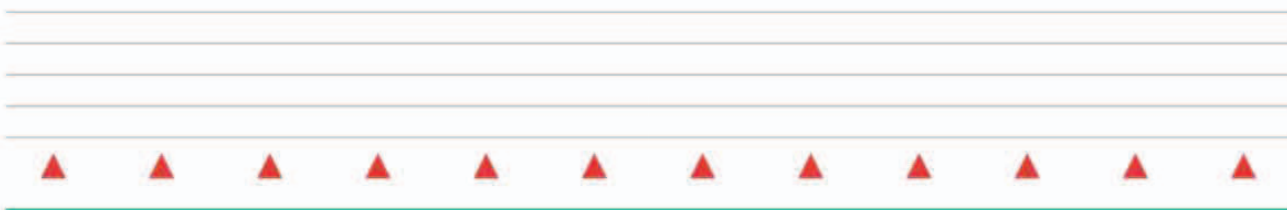
Note values

26–27 ▶

Beats

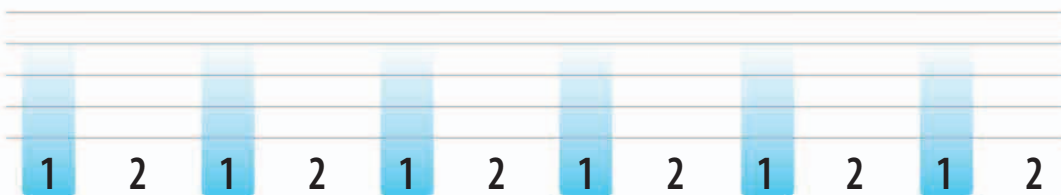
Beats are music's heartbeat. Underlying each piece of music is a regular beat or pulse, irrespective of whether it is fast or slow, or whether we can hear it or not. We can only feel it; it is the background to the music.

- 4 ▼ **A regular beat**
The red triangles represent a regular beat or pulse. They are not the actual music, but we need to feel the beat even before we start playing.



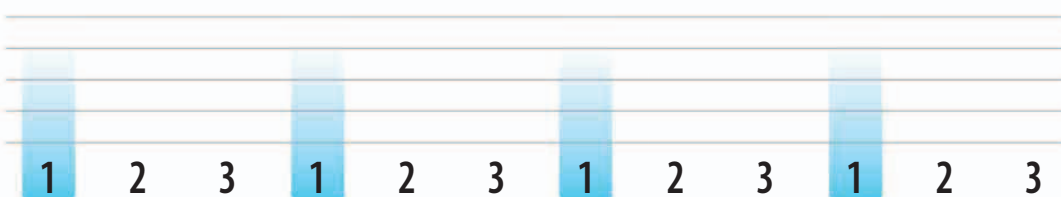
Meter

When a regular pattern of accents is imposed on the pulse, so that some beats are stronger than others, it is called a meter. The meter gives the beat a character, depending on how many weak beats come between each strong beat. The beats can be marked off in groups of 2, 3, or 4.



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- ◀ **In 2s**
Try repeating the numbers in a regular pattern, like a march, 1, 2, 1, 2, emphasizing the 1s.



6

- ◀ **In 3s**
Now shift to 3-time, repeating the numbers 1, 2, 3, 1, 2, 3, 1, 2, 3, still emphasizing the 1s.



7

- ◀ **In 4s**
These beats are grouped in 4s: one of the most common musical meters, especially in pop music.